TWO

Contribution to the Transition

THEY CALLED US in on a Saturday, which should have told me everything.

There were almond croissants on the boardroom table, arranged in a fan on a white plate, the way a hotel arranges things it wants you to photograph. Nobody touched them. Nine of us sat round the table in weekend clothes, and the croissants sat in the middle like a tenth person who'd come to the wrong meeting and was too polite to leave.

The man from head office had a lanyard and a clicker. He was younger than any of us and he was very kind, which was the worst part. He showed us a map of the country on the big screen, every Coyle's depot a small amber dot, and then he pressed the clicker and the dots began to move.

"It's live," he said. "As of this morning."

I watched a lorry leave the northern depot on the screen and take a road I would never have chosen, and then I watched the reason appear, three minutes later, as a closure on the motorway that none of us had known about yet. It had seen the future, or near enough. It had seen it before I'd finished my coffee.

I remember thinking, with a kind of professional admiration I've never quite forgiven myself for: *that's good.*

"Nobody's losing their job today," the man from head office said, and nine people heard the last word.

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IT TOOK ELEVEN months. They were decent about it, which I'm told is rare. Nobody was walked out of the building with a cardboard box. Instead the team got smaller the way a room gets darker at the end of a summer evening: so gradually that you only notice when you try to read.

Priya went first, to a job up north she'd been sitting on for a year. Then the two lads who did nights, whose shift simply stopped existing. Then Maureen from planning, sixty-one, who said she'd been meaning to retire anyway, and cried in the car park where she thought no one could see. Then the others, one every month or so, each with a card that we all signed and a cake that the system didn't eat.

By Christmas there were two of us and a contractor in a time zone I had to keep looking up. By February there was me.

I was kept on to *support the transition*. That meant I sat beside the routing system for eight hours a day and told it when it was wrong. It was hardly ever wrong. When it was, it was wrong in ways I'd have been wrong too, and it learned from me faster than I'd ever learned from anyone. I was training my own replacement, and my replacement was a very good student.

The system ran on something called Nimfold, which I'd seen on the news, licensed through a cloud I'd also seen on the news. The contractor talked about both the way people talk about the weather in a country where the weather never changes. *Nimfold's pushing an update tonight. The cloud's a bit slow in the mornings.* It was everywhere and nowhere, and it had my job.

I don't want to make it sound worse than it was. I was paid. I was thanked. Every Friday someone from human resources sent

me an email asking how I was *feeling about the journey*, and every Friday I wrote back *fine*. It was true in the way that weather reports are true.

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WHEN I JOINED Coyle's I was twenty-six and I knew nothing, and a man called Pete taught me everything.

Pete had been planning routes since before I was born. He kept a green pen in his shirt pocket and corrected my spreadsheets with it in a small, upright hand. He never told me I was wrong. He'd circle a number, write *why?* in the margin, and wait. Sometimes the waiting took a day. He'd go and make a cup of tea and come back and say nothing, and I'd sit there with my circled number until I understood it. That was how I learned the job: beside someone who already knew it, with a question in green ink and all the time in the world.

Pete retired in 2016 and died the year after Dad. I went to the funeral and didn't know anyone, and on the way out his daughter gave me a green pen from a box of them she'd found in his garage. I keep it in the drawer with the takeaway menus. I've never used it. I don't know what I'd circle.

The system doesn't circle anything. It doesn't ask *why?* It doesn't wait. I never once saw it wonder.

On my last day at the desk, a Thursday in March, it routed a refrigerated lorry from the container port through a town I knew was holding a market that morning. It wasn't in any data. It was the kind of thing you knew because a driver had once been stuck behind a cheese stall for forty minutes and had told you about it in some detail, twice. I watched the little amber dot head for the market, and I reached for the override, and then I stopped.

I sat there with my hand on the mouse and thought: *why?*

Not why the system had done it. I knew why. Nobody had told it about the cheese stall, because the man who knew about the cheese stall had taken early retirement and moved to Spain. I

meant: why was I about to fix it? Who was I fixing it for? In three weeks there would be nobody at this desk to know about markets, and the lorry would go through the town anyway, and somebody would wait forty minutes for their fish, and nobody would ever know whose fault it was, because it wouldn't be anybody's.

I fixed it. Of course I fixed it. Old habits, Pete would have said. But I remember the four seconds before I did. They were the first four seconds in eleven months when I'd seen the shape of the thing clearly: not a machine taking my job, but a world quietly arranging itself so that no one would be there to notice what was lost.

The lorry missed the market. The fish arrived on time. Nobody said thank you, because nobody knew.

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THE LETTER CAME in March. It was on Coyle's paper, which still had the old logo with the lorry on it, and it was signed by a director I'd met twice.

Dear Nell,

Thank you for your contribution to the transition.

I read it at my kitchen table with a cup of tea going cold. Across from me on the shelf was my father's crossword dictionary, the spine broken in three places from forty years of being opened at the same letters. Under the tea was my rent statement, which I'd been using as a coaster, with a letterhead I'd never once looked at properly: some property services company, a logo like a bird, a payment reference as long as a sentence. I'd been paying them for six years and couldn't have told you their name.

Contribution to the transition. I read it until the words came apart, the way a word does if you say it too often. *Contribution*, as if I'd put money in a tin. *Transition*, as if I were a season, and it was simply time for me to turn.

It said there would be a final project before the end of my notice. The company's archive was moving to digital, and "given your long familiarity with our records", they would be grateful if I

could oversee the review.

They wanted the person they were letting go to decide what to keep.

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THE ARCHIVE WAS in a storage unit by the old rail yard, in a row of identical units with roller doors and fluorescent strips that took a moment to make up their minds. You let yourself in with a keycard. It beeped when you went in and beeped when you came out, which I noticed the first day and stopped noticing by the second. You stop hearing what a building says about you if it says it politely enough.

Inside it was eighty years of paper in cardboard boxes gone soft at the corners. Manifests, invoices, vehicle logs, bills of lading. A lifetime of things being moved from one place to another and somebody writing it down.

People think archive work is boring, and they're right, but they're right in the wrong way. It's boring the way the sea is boring. After the first few hundred documents your eyes stop reading and start *sorting*. Paper from the same year has the same weight in your hand, the same typeface, the same tired clerk's initials in the corner. Your attention goes quiet, and all that's left is a low hum that only changes when something doesn't fit.

I worked like that for three weeks. I scanned what mattered and shredded what didn't. Most of it didn't. I ate my lunch on an upturned crate and listened to the trains I couldn't see. I was, for the first time in a year, good at something nobody could do better, because nobody else had been asked.

On Monday the twentieth of April, at about four in the afternoon, the hum changed.

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THE BOX WAS labelled **1971 Q1 — MISC.** in marker pen that had faded to the colour of weak tea. It was under forty others, and

when I opened it, it smelled the way old paper smells: of nothing, almost, and then of dust and something sweeter underneath, like a church.

Halfway down there was a single manifest. A standard Coyle's form of the period, the kind I'd seen a thousand of that month. One consignment, collected from somewhere called **Harrowgate House and delivered to The Ashby Trust, care of a PO box. The cargo line had been typed on a machine whose* e* was slightly raised:

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OFFICE EQUIPMENT — TELETYPE APPARATUS, 1 UNIT.
                HANDLE AS INSTRUCTED.
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My hands knew before I did. That's the only way I can describe it. My hands stopped.

There was no weight. Every Coyle's manifest has a weight, because weight is what we bill by, and this one had a neat pencil line through the box, like a question someone had been told not to ask. There was no charge, no rate and no invoice number, on a firm that has never moved a paperclip for free. Where the date should have been, someone had written **D. 3062**. I thought it was a docket number until I checked the dockets, and it wasn't.

And across the bottom, in purple from a rubber stamp, slightly crooked, as if pressed by someone who had done it many times and stopped looking:

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*FOR THE LONG WEATHER*
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No company name. No logo. Four words in a colour you'd choose for a wedding invitation.

I sat on my crate with the sheet in my hands for a long time. The fluorescent strip ticked. Somewhere beyond the yard a train went past and didn't stop.

I want to be honest about what I felt, because everything afterwards depends on it, and because I've since learned how easy it is to remember being braver than you were. I didn't feel fear. I felt *recognised*. I'd spent eleven months being told, kindly, that the

thing I was good at no longer mattered, and here was a piece of paper that had been made, by someone careful, to look exactly like the thousand pieces of paper around it, and it had failed, and I was the only person alive who could have noticed.

It was the least important document in the building. And it was the first thing in a year that had needed me.

I put it in a plastic sleeve and took it home in my bag, which I'm fairly sure was against company policy. The keycard beeped when I left. I didn't hear it.

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I COULDN'T SLEEP, so at eleven o'clock I rang Danny.

Danny Kessler was a union rep for twenty years, until there was no union left to represent, and he now delivers parcels for an app that rates him out of five. He answered on the second ring, because people who drive for apps don't sleep either.

"It's a tax dodge," he said, when I'd read it to him twice.

"You haven't seen it."

"I don't need to see it. Rich people moving things off the books. I've seen a thousand of them. They used to make me sign half of them." A pause, and the sound of a kettle. "Why are you whispering?"

I hadn't known I was. I didn't have an answer, so I told him I'd send him a photo, and he said he'd look in the morning, and then he said, the way he always does at the end of a call, as if it were part of the goodbye: "Don't let it get in your head, Nell."

It was already in my head. It had been in my head since four o'clock.

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AT ONE IN the morning I opened my laptop at the kitchen table, under my father's crossword dictionary and beside my bird-logo coaster, and I started a blog.

I want to say I had a plan. I didn't. What I had was a sheet of paper that didn't add up, and a skill nobody wanted, and the feeling, which I'd had all my working life, that if something isn't written down it hasn't happened. The routing system could plan a route. It could not, as far as I knew, sit at a kitchen table at one in the morning and say *I know how this sounds.*

I needed a name. I didn't want my own, not yet. My father used to call the hour after work, when he'd finally sit down with the crossword, his *vespers*: the evening prayer, though he hadn't been inside a church in thirty years. *Leave me to my vespers, Nellie.* So I called myself Vesper, because it was evening, and because I missed him, and because it sounded like the kind of name someone would use if they had something to hide, which I didn't. Yet.

I wrote for two hours. I wrote about the croissants and the clicker and the man with the lanyard. I wrote about the box, and the pencil line, and the date that wasn't a date, and the four words in purple. I wrote that I wasn't neutral, and that people should keep that in mind. I wrote the first true thing I'd written in a year, which was that I knew how this sounded.

At ten past three I pressed *publish*.

Then I sat and looked at it. There it was, out in the dark with nobody reading it, like a lantern in a field.